

The "Knockout" Gate (Binary Pass/Fail):

RIT Connection: Is there a founder, C-suite, or IP link to RIT?

Thesis Alignment: Does it fall into: *Photonics/Quantum, Clean Tech, Life Science, or Intelligent Systems?*

Stage: Is it Seed to Series A?

Tech-Enabled: Is there proprietary IP or a "Hard Tech" barrier to entry? (We do not fund pure services/apps).

Category	Score (1-5)	Weight	Weighted Score
1. Team ("Builders")	[]	x 5	= _____
2. Tech ("Defensibility")	[]	x 4	= _____
3. Commercial ("Efficiency")	[]	x 5	= _____
4. RIT Fit ("Leverage")	[]	x 4	= _____
5. Deal Dynamics	[]	x 2	= _____
TOTAL			_____/100

Maximum Score: 100

- **80 – 100** Move to deep diligence immediately. This is a "Head & Hands" winner.
- **70 – 79 (The "Maybe"):** **Hold.** Usually missing one key element (e.g., a commercial co-founder). Can we fix this? If not, pass.
- **Below 70:** **Move on to the next deal.**

Score each sub-category on a scale of **1 (Weak)** to **5 (Exceptional)**.

I. TEAM COMPOSITION: "Technical Builders" (Weight: 25%)

- **Commercial/Technical Balance:** Does the founding team have both deep domain expertise (PhD/Engineering) *and* a commercial leader who can sell?
- **Coachability/Grit:** Evidence of pivoting based on data? Are they defensive or receptive?
- **Talent Magnetism:** Have they convinced high-quality people (advisors, early hires) to join for equity?

II. TECHNICAL DEFENSIBILITY: The "Moat" (Weight: 20%)

- **IP Protection:** Are there patents filed/granted? Is the IP defensible or trade-secret based?
- **External Validation:** Has the tech been validated by third parties (peer-reviewed journals, RIT Faculty review, Paid Pilots)?
- **Development Stage:** Is it a concept, a prototype, or a deployed product? (Higher score for "Hardware in the Loop").

III. COMMERCIAL VIABILITY: "Capital Efficiency" (Weight: 25%)

- **Capital Efficiency:** Have they leveraged grants (SBIR/STTR), competitions, or customer deposits to de-risk before asking for equity?
- **Path to Revenue:** Is there a clear LOI (Letter of Intent) or contract pipeline?
- **Market Pain:** Is this a "Vitamin" (nice to have) or a "Painkiller" (must have)?
- **Unit Economics:** Do the margins make sense at scale?

IV. THE RIT LEVERAGE: "Force Multiplier" (Weight: 20%)

- **Structural Advantage:** Does 1829 Ventures investing here give them an unfair advantage? (e.g., Access to the Battery Prototyping Center, Clean Room, or specific Faculty).
- **Talent Pipeline:** Can they utilize RIT Co-ops or hires to lower their burn rate?
- **Mission Alignment:** Does the success of this company enhance the RIT brand (like Kanvas)?

V. DEAL DYNAMICS: "Risk Mitigation" (Weight: 10%)

- **Syndicate Strength:** Who is leading? Are we following a "Smart Lead" (like DCVC) or are we the only capital?
- **Valuation Discipline:** Is the entry price reasonable for the stage?